for its amusement value. It is fun to play with, since it is

so heavy and so nonwetting. Unfortunately, Gertrude did not remove her wedding ring while playing with it and mercury will not only wet gold, it also will mix with it readily. Her ring turned a silvery color.

I took the wedding ring to school the next day and tried driving off the mercury by heating it gently under vacuum. That merely turned it from a silvery color to a dull-gray one. I then tried to heat it more strongly in a Bunsen burner flame and the gold began to melt. (That was one of my more stupid feats since there were sound chemical reasons—I won't bore you with them—for anticipating just that.) I snatched the ring out of the flame but it was clearly ruined.

Eventually, John Blugerman removed the mercury, which was only in the gold surface, by drilling it off with a dental drill, but the ring wasn't really useful thereafter.

I missed that ring, too. It had been engraved with our initials and the wedding date.

11

For once I was getting along with a superior. Professor Dawson and I were soulmates.

This was not because I had ceased to be me. It was entirely because Dawson didn't mind my peculiarities. Indeed, he was amused by them.

For one thing, I was always running into him with excited ideas, or comments, or results. "Phenomenon-a-minute Asimov" he used to refer to me in speaking to others.

Sometimes the excitement arose over something not entirely creditable to myself.

One time, for instance, I reported to him that a sample of enzyme wasn't working no matter what I did. I was very gloomy about it for I couldn't understand what I had done wrong. And then I became aware of the fact that I was not using a 2-milliliter pipette, but a 0.2-milliliter one—one that had only one tenth the capacity of the former, though it had the same outward dimensions. Therefore I was always adding just one tenth the amount of enzyme I thought I was adding.